

Council Meeting

June 5, 2021

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The Claremont City Council held a Budget meeting on Saturday, June 5, 2021, in the Council Chambers of City Hall.

The meeting was called to order by Mayor Lovett at 9:00 a.m.

Members of the Council present:

Ward I Councilor Andrew O’Hearne

At-Large Councilor Dale Girard

At-Large Councilor Michael Demars

Assistant Mayor Allen Damren

Mayor Charlene Lovett

At-Large Councilor Debora Matteau

At-Large Councilor Nicholas Koloski

Ward II Councilor James Contois (joined the meeting via Zoom – home, alone)

Ward III Councilor Jonathan Stone

Also present:

Edward Morris, City Manager

Mary Walter, Finance Director

AGENDA CHANGES

None

CITIZEN’S FORUM

None

NEW BUSINESS (BUDGET)

Mr. Morris said the Council gave directives to continue paving, working on blight, follow Master Plan to look at facilities, and this budget includes that. The other directive was to level fund the tax rate and this budget does that. He will talk about ARPA (American Rescue Plan Act) funds during the Revenue discussion. He talked about a GFOA (Government Finance Officers Association) distinguished budget and adding that information into the budget book in the future.

Assessing

Department Request \$199,433.00

City Manager Proposed \$198,707.00

Stephan Hamilton, Interim Assessor, said this budget is slightly lower than FY21. He gave some background about what Assessing does. He talked about Assessing Technician Kimberlee Burkhamer moving toward certification as an Assessor Assistant.

Regarding Regular Pay, Mr. Morris said he is proposing a 2% increase for Merit Plan employees (2% to go into effect in January) and then whatever is in the Union contracts. That is listed throughout the budget.

Regarding Health Insurance, Mr. Morris said that Merit Plan employees who were at 7% contribution, have been moved to 10%, and that is reflected in this budget.

A motion was made by Councilor Koloski and seconded by Councilor Stone to tentatively approve the Assessing Budget for \$198,707.00.

Roll call vote:

Girard - yes

Demars - yes

Damren - yes

Matteau - yes

Koloski - yes

Contois - yes

Stone - yes

Lovett - yes

Motion carried 8-0.

Planning & Development

Department Request \$868,278.00

City Manager Proposed \$855,355.00

Nancy Merrill, Planning and Development Director, gave a brief description of the Planning and Development Department. When asked about her wish list for staffing, Ms. Merrill said she would like to add a half-time administrative assistant to help with grant administration and half-time zoning officer to help with enforcement. Mayor Lovett would like to see an analysis of those two positions, cost of each and what more could be accomplished with them.

There was discussion about heating and cooling the building and Mayor Lovett said she wanted more analysis.

There was discussion about repairing or taking down the Sullivan stack and the pumphouse and Council agreed this is a priority.

TIFD-Downtown

Department Request \$729,550.00

City Manager Proposed \$719,550.00

Ms. Walter said that in three more years, two bonds, which add up to \$500,000, will be paid off. She talked about a capital reserve for the Sawtooth Parking Garage. It is 10 years old and has no replacement plan.

A motion was made by Assistant Mayor Damren and seconded by Councilor Matteau to tentatively approve the TIFD-Downtown Budget for \$719,550.00 Expenses and \$719,550.00 Revenue.

Roll call vote:

Girard - yes

Demars - yes

Damren - yes

Matteau - yes

Koloski - yes

Contois - yes

Stone - yes

Lovett - yes

Motion carried 8-0.

Water

Department Request \$2,097,316.00

City Manager Proposed \$2,071,766.00

Alex Gleeson, Public Works Director, and Jeremy Clay, Assistant Public Works Director, were in attendance. Mr. Gleeson gave some background information about the Water Department.

There was a discussion about water revenues going down; the City's not losing users, but people are conserving water. Also, restaurants were closed for three months due to the pandemic.

Councilor Koloski would like to establish capital reserves for vehicles. Mayor Lovett said to put this as an agenda item in July.

At 10:39 a.m., Councilor O'Hearne arrived.

Sewer

Department Request \$2,894,669.00

City Manager Proposed \$2,888,104.00

There was discussion about the dryer for sludge (very expensive) and looking for other efficiencies.

Council asked to be sent information about the solar array.

Sanitation (Transfer Station)

Department Request \$241,680.00

City Manager Proposed \$226,076.00

Jeremy Clay, Assistant Public Works Director, answered Councilors questions.

Councilor Koloski suggested the Ad Hoc Transfer Station Committee be reinstituted. He would like to see a long-term plan for City departments' trash removal. Mayor Lovett said this can go on an agenda. She agreed there is a need to resurrect the ad hoc committee.

Regarding the future use of the closed landfill, Mr. Clay said it would be perfect for three-phase power.

A motion was made by Assistant Mayor Damren and seconded by Councilor Matteau to tentatively approve the Sanitation (Transfer Station) Budget for \$226,076.00.

Roll call vote:

O'Hearne - yes

Girard - yes

Demars - yes

Damren - yes

Matteau - yes

Koloski - yes

Contois - yes

Stone - no

Lovett - yes

Motion carried 8-1.

Cemetery

Department Request \$207,875.00

City Manager Proposed \$193,539.00

Alex Gleeson, Public Works Director, gave a brief description of the work done in the cemeteries. Regarding future plans, Mr. Clay said that Mountainview Cemetery can expand. There is an account to purchase or expand land within the City, but, we don't expect to have to use it for another 25 years.

A motion was made by Assistant Mayor Damren and seconded by Councilor Stone to tentatively approve the Cemetery Budget for \$193,539.00.

Roll call vote:

O'Hearne - yes

Girard - yes

Demars - yes

Damren - yes

Matteau - yes

Koloski - yes

Contois - yes

Stone - yes

Lovett - yes

Motion carried 9-0.

Streets & Roads (Highways)

Department Request \$4,298,968.00

City Manager Proposed \$3,316,779.00

Mr. Clay gave some background information. He talked about the hook & lift system making vehicles more versatile.

He listed roads on the paving list: Grove Street, part of Memorial Street, Memorial Circle, Myrtle Street. This next spring, they will pave Red Water Brook Road. Cat Hole Road will be paved this summer.

Councilor Koloski would like to add \$100,000 more into Paving if it can be found elsewhere in the budget.

Councilor Demars thinks \$100,000 is not enough and that he would be willing to cut some staff positions to get to \$1 million. Mr. Morris said that at a certain point there would not be enough crew to do the work that the additional money would pay for. Mayor Lovett asked if now would be the time to have a discussion about taking out a bond. Ms. Walter said in two years, a bond would be paid off. Mayor Lovett said this discussion would be added to an agenda.

Mr. Morris said this past winter was a light winter, so he's working to move that money (\$155,000) into Paving this year.

Councilor Matteau agreed \$650,000 was not enough for Paving and would like to put another \$100,000 into it.

Assistant Mayor Damren said he would be against laying off a person or defunding a position in order to put the money toward Roads.

Councilor Stone said he would support moving the vacant position money into Paving. He thinks the City should try to work up to \$1 million for Paving.

Councilor Matteau would like to see an analysis of the past 10 years of staffing at Public Works as well as looking at how much time there were vacancies as well as how much we've increased contracted services.

Councilor Demars agreed with Councilor Stone about taking the money of the vacant position and adding it to Paving.

Mayor Lovett said Council Goals have Paving at a minimum of \$750,000. Eventually, this will be an agenda item with other options.

Communications 911 - Dispatching

Department Request \$588,341.00

City Manager Proposed \$595,324.00

Police Chief Mark Chase gave an overview of the Communications 911 - Dispatching and Police budgets. He said the records management system has been in service since 1998 and the recording system is nearing the end of its life, as well.

A motion was made by Assistant Mayor Damren and seconded by Councilor Matteau to tentatively approve the Communications 911 - Dispatching Budget for \$595,324.00.

Roll call vote:

O'Hearne - yes

Girard - yes

Demars - yes

Damren - yes

Matteau - yes

Koloski - yes

Contois - yes

Stone - yes

Lovett - yes

Motion carried 9-0.

Police Budget

Department Request \$3,260,645.00

City Manager Proposed \$3,216,629.00

Chief Chase gave some more information about the Police Department. He said that all law enforcement agencies are struggling to find applicants. It is difficult to hire in Claremont with our pay rates. There are four vacant patrol positions.

Mr. Morris cautioned against taking money out of this budget for a year; it will yo-yo the tax rate when it is added back. If a position is not filled, that money can be moved to Paving.

Chief Chase said with the COPS Grant funded position, that it cannot be used to supplement a vacant position.

A motion was made by Assistant Mayor Damren and seconded by Councilor Koloski to tentatively approve the Police Budget for \$3,216,629.00.

Roll call vote:

O'Hearne - no

Girard - no

Demars - no

Damren - yes

Matteau - yes

Koloski - yes

Contois - yes

Stone - no

Lovett - yes

Motion carried 5-4.

Fire

Department Request \$2,581,857.00

City Manager Proposed \$2,555,496.00

Fire Chief Bryan Burr gave some background about staffing, including Call Firefighters, in the Fire Department and how important it is to keep what they have (four people on a shift) and not reduce that number as that would be unsafe. He said that turnout time is less than 1 minute and they can respond anywhere in the City within 5 minutes. Mr. Morris said that fire doubles in size every minute.

Councilor Koloski said he wanted to go on record that he hopes Call Firefighters don't go away. They are always a valuable resource. Chief Burr said there are 8 Call Firefighters and he is not planning to reduce that number.

A motion was made by Councilor O'Hearne and seconded by Councilor Stone to tentatively approve the Fire Budget for \$2,555,496.00.

Roll call vote:

O'Hearne - yes

Girard - yes

Demars - yes

Damren - yes

Matteau - yes

Koloski - yes

Contois - yes

Stone - yes

Lovett - yes

Motion carried 9-0.

Airport

Department Request \$120,465.00

City Manager Proposed \$120,465.00

Chief Burr said next year the Airport will be closed for 90 days for runway construction.

A motion was made by Councilor O'Hearne and seconded by Councilor Matteau to tentatively approve the Airport Budget for \$120,465.00.

Roll call vote:

O'Hearne - yes

Girard - yes

Demars - yes

Damren - yes

Matteau - yes

Koloski - yes
Contois - yes
Stone - yes
Lovett - yes
Motion carried 9-0.

Parks

Department Request \$423,739.00 City Manager Proposed \$402,819.00

Mark Brislin, Parks and Recreation Director, gave a quick overview of Parks and CSB Community Center - Recreation.

There was a brief discussion about combining the Parks and the CSBCC budgets and it was agreed it should be an agenda item.

There was discussion about the tennis courts and if they are not repaired, they will have to be closed.

A motion was made by Assistant Mayor Damren and seconded by Councilor Girard to tentatively approve the Parks Budget for \$402,819.00.

Roll call vote:
O'Hearne - yes
Girard - yes
Demars - yes
Damren - yes
Matteau - yes
Koloski - yes
Contois - yes
Stone - yes
Lovett - yes
Motion carried 9-0.

CSB Community Center – Recreation

Department Request \$1,155,741.00 City Manager Proposed \$1,154,011.00

Mr. Brislin answered Councilor's questions. Regarding maintaining the building, Ms. Walter said there is a capital reserve that was established when the building was opened.

There was discussion about the CSBCC not putting more than \$500,000 on the tax rate, however, prices are increasing. This will need to be an agenda item.

A motion was made by Councilor Demars and seconded by Councilor Matteau to tentatively approve the CSB Community Center – Recreation Budget for \$1,154,011.00.

Roll call vote:

O'Hearne - yes

Girard - yes

Demars - yes

Damren - yes

Matteau - yes

Koloski - yes

Contois - yes

Stone - yes

Lovett - yes

Motion carried 9-0.

Municipal Complex (Maintenance)

Department Request \$456,375.00

City Manager Proposed \$401,017.00

Mr. Morris said the facilities team is now under Parks and Recreation.

Regarding automatic air handler controls, Mayor Lovett asked for a cost benefit analysis.

A motion was made by Councilor Matteau and seconded by Councilor Girard to tentatively approve the Municipal Complex (Maintenance) Budget for \$401,017.00.

Roll call vote:

O'Hearne - yes

Girard - yes

Demars - yes

Damren - yes

Matteau - yes

Koloski - yes

Contois - yes

Stone - yes

Lovett - yes

Motion carried 9-0.

Welfare

Department Request \$404,810.00

City Manager Proposed \$392,979.00

Suzanne Carr, Welfare Director, gave some background about the Welfare Department.

Regarding staffing, she said it takes more time to not spend money, case management. She said the NH Municipal Association and the NH Local Welfare Administrators Association have redone the Model Welfare Guidelines, so she will come back to the Council with updates to the guidelines.

A motion was made by Councilor O'Hearne and seconded by Assistant Mayor Damren to tentatively approve the Welfare Budget for \$392,979.00.

Roll call vote:

O'Hearne - yes

Girard - yes

Demars - yes

Damren - yes

Matteau - yes

Koloski - yes

Contois - yes

Stone - yes

Lovett - yes

Motion carried 9-0.

Library

Department Request \$418,076.00

City Manager Proposed \$417,738.00

Michael Grace, Library Director, gave some background about the Library. Regarding the dark staining on the outside bricks, it was from coal burning and you would have to take away part of the brick in order to remove it. Because it is a yellow brick building, it shows more than red brick would.

There was discussion about replacing the carpeting. It was unknown when it was installed, however, the Library has been asking for funds to replace it for many years.

This budget was not tentatively approved in order to get an estimate for the carpet.

Mr. Grace said the copper on the roof needs to be done. The plan is to get an estimate this summer.

Policy

Department Request \$584,700.00

City Manager Proposed \$589,820.00

Mr. Morris said Consulting Services was for the Finance Director search, but if left in the budget, it could be used for the strategic planning process.

A motion was made by Assistant Mayor Damren and seconded by Councilor Girard to tentatively approve the Policy Budget for \$589,820.00.

Roll call vote:

O'Hearne - yes

Girard - yes

Demars - yes

Damren - yes
Matteau - yes
Koloski - yes
Contois - yes
Stone - yes
Lovett - yes
Motion carried 9-0.

Outside Agency Request

Department Request \$30,000.00

City Manager Proposed \$30,000.00

Ms. Walter said this comes from fund balance.

A motion was made by Councilor Demars and seconded by Councilor Matteau to tentatively approve the Outside Agency Request Budget for \$30,000.00.

Roll call vote:
O’Hearne - yes
Girard - yes
Demars - yes
Damren - yes
Matteau - yes
Koloski - yes
Contois - yes
Stone - yes
Lovett - yes
Motion carried 9-0.

City Administration (Finance)

Department Request \$936,054.00

City Manager Proposed \$914,589.00

Ms. Walter gave some background information, including that Claremont’s Central Collections was one of the only ones to stay open in the state during the pandemic. Kudos to her staff. She said that Lisa Richmond, City’s Treasurer, will replace her when she retires in July.

Mayor Lovett asked about a plan for cybersecurity, enhanced measures.

Councilor O’Hearne is not in favor of outsourcing IT. He thinks it should be its own department. Mayor Lovett said that would be an agenda item.

A motion was made by Assistant Mayor Damren and seconded by Councilor Matteau to tentatively approve the City Administration (Finance) Budget for \$914,589.00.

Roll call vote:

O'Hearne - no

Girard - no

Demars - no

Damren - yes

Matteau - yes

Koloski - no

Contois - yes

Stone - no

Lovett - yes

Motion failed 4-5.

Mayor Lovett said there will have to be another budget meeting.

Elections

Department Request \$11,550.00

City Manager Proposed \$11,550.00

There was discussion about replacing voter machines. Ms. Walter said that \$3,685 has been set aside, and four machines could cost \$20,000.

A motion was made by Councilor Koloski and seconded by Councilor O'Hearne to tentatively approve the Elections Budget for \$11,550.00.

Roll call vote:

O'Hearne - yes

Girard - yes

Demars - yes

Damren - yes

Matteau - yes

Koloski - yes

Contois - yes

Stone - yes

Lovett - yes

Motion carried 9-0.

Debt Retirement

Department Request \$1,127,872.00

City Manager Proposed \$1,127,872.00

A motion was made by Councilor O'Hearne and seconded by Councilor Matteau to tentatively approve the Debt Retirement Budget for \$1,127,872.00.

Roll call vote:

O'Hearne - yes

Girard - yes

Demars - yes
Damren - yes
Matteau - yes
Koloski - yes
Contois - yes
Stone - yes
Lovett - yes
Motion carried 9-0.

General Services

Department Request \$1,482,380.00 City Manager Proposed \$1,090,980.00

Ms. Walter said this budget is a conglomeration of items shared by the City. Started compensation reserve to help pay future retirement and GASB, which we have not funded for several years. Loan to downtown TIFD is going down. Regarding Overlay and War Service Credits, the City tries to budget some amount, so when the tax rate is set by DRA, there is not such a big change in the proposed tax rate.

There was a discussion about legal services and Mayor Lovett said it would be nice to see an analysis of costs.

Regarding GASB liability, Ms. Walter said we keep not funding this and we are told we should have \$1.5 million; it's an unfunded liability.

A motion was made by Assistant Mayor Damren and seconded by Councilor Girard to tentatively approve the General Services Budget for \$1,090,980.00.

Roll call vote:
O'Hearne - yes
Girard - yes
Demars - yes
Damren - yes
Matteau - yes
Koloski - yes
Contois - yes
Stone - yes
Lovett - yes
Motion carried 9-0.

Revenue

Department Request \$5,170,492.00 City Manager Proposed \$6,225,104.00

Mr. Morris talked about ARPA (American Rescue Plan Act) funds, explaining the Treasury guidance. They wanted to keep governments as whole as possible. These are projections. If we

get Meals & Rooms, we don't have to use ARPA funds. The City can go back to January 2020 for lost revenue.

Council agreed to meet June 22, 2021, 6:30 p.m. to finalize the budget before the public hearing.

CONSULTATION WITH LEGAL COUNSEL

None

ADJOURNMENT

At 4:44 p.m., a motion was made by Councilor Matteau and seconded by Councilor O'Hearne to adjourn.

Roll call vote:

O'Hearne - yes

Girard - yes

Demars - yes

Damren - yes

Matteau - yes

Koloski - yes

Contois - yes

Stone - yes

Lovett - yes

Motion carried 9-0.

Respectfully Submitted,

Dorée M. Russell
Clerk to the Council